

THE HIT LIST

The LTTE targeted it's political opponents, eliminating dozens.



ALFRED DURAIPPAH
JULY 27, 1975
Jaffna mayor whose killing sparked the war.

SIRI SABARATINAM
MAY 6, 1986

The founder of the Tamil Eelam Liberation Organisation.

A. AMIRTHALINGAM
JULY 13, 1989

TULF leader known for his moderate views shot dead.



R. PREMADASA
MAY 1, 1993
President who sided with the LTTE and then fell out with them.

K. PADMANABHA
JUNE 19, 1990

Eelam People's Revolutionary Liberation Front chief shot dead.

RANJAN WIJERATNE
MARCH 2, 1991

Minister of State for Defence was killed by a car bomb.



RAJIV GANDHI
MAY 21, 1991
Assassinated by a woman suicide bomber during a poll campaign.

A. THANGADURAI
JULY 2, 1992

THE TULF MP was killed in a bomb attack in Trincomalee.



GAMINI DISSANAYAKE
OCT 24, 1994
Opposition leader, killed by a LTTE woman bomber.

LAKSHMAN KADIRAGAMAR
AUGUST 12, 2005

Sri Lankan foreign minister was shot dead by a LTTE sniper.

cently arrested LTTE functionary to verify that it was indeed the Tiger chief.

Another area of controversy among experts was, that given his military prowess, why didn't Prabhakaran have in place a Plan B to escape out of Sri Lanka, as the army dragnet closed in around him. That would have enabled him and his top lieutenants to regroup and fight another day. Fonseka believes that the reasons why Prabhakaran didn't give up the fight was either because he was loathe to surrender and believed in his invincibility or he couldn't find a country that would provide him shelter. Or maybe he had hoped that the Lankan Tamil diaspora would mount enough international pressure over the collateral damage to civilians and get them to force the Government to declare a ceasefire. Defence Secretary Gotabaya Rajapakse says dismissively: "Prabhakaran didn't really have a Plan B, C or D.

The LTTE chief was not such a great strategist as he was made out to be."

That was evident especially in the past five years. At the peak of his power in 2004, Prabhakaran could have agreed to a peace pact that would have resulted in unprecedented devolution of powers to the North and the East provinces where a majority of the Tamils reside. Possibly even more than what the Tamils would have got under the Indo-Sri Lankan Accord of 1987 signed between the then prime minister Rajiv Gandhi and President J. Jayawardene. But Prabhakaran was so chuffed that he failed to see that international opinion had irrevocably altered against terror organisations like his after 9/11. With US and Europe clamping down on illegal funds, LTTE suddenly found its regular sources, especially from the diaspora drying up.

Meanwhile, in order to sow the seeds of political divisions among the majority Sinhala parties, he had the Tamils boycott the 2005 presidential elections to ensure the defeat of prime minister Ranil Wickremesinghe of the United National Party. That brought the People's Alliance candidate Mahinda

Rajapakse, who had run a Sinhala chauvinistic election campaign, to power. Prabhakaran believed that the rivalry between former President Chandrika Kumaratunge and Rajapakse would further weaken the Sinhala ability to battle with him. But he hadn't counted on Rajapakse's resolve and canniness to launch a sustained military offensive against him. By appointing his brother Gotabaya as defence secretary and giving Fonseka carte blanche to eliminate the Tigers, Rajapakse put into place a rare and decisive politico-military unity.

Backed by the President, Fonseka began to overhaul the sluggish and effete Sri Lankan Army. Instead of using seniority, he promoted meritorious officers to command the divisions that he was to push against Prabhakaran. He then got the Government to add almost 80,000 additional troops with ade-



We will not allow any Tigers to return. We don't want a stupid ending to our win."

SARATH FONSEKA
Chief, Sri Lankan Army



quate equipment. Rajapakse made it clear that he would shop anywhere to buy weapons, relying largely on China and to some extent Pakistan to give him the bulk. India had no option but to look the other way as it had decided after the withdrawal of the Indian Peace Keeping Force in 1990, it would no more provide military support to enhance Sri Lanka's offensive capability.

Equally important was that Fonseka changed the tactics of the Sri Lankan Army by forming special infantry units of eight members each to carry out guerrilla strikes in the Wanni jungles similar to what the Tigers used to do. Fonseka was determined to learn from the lessons of the past and instead of trying to secure control of the high-ways he moved his troops into the jungles and began a systematic flushing out operation. Prabhakaran mean-